Heaven Under Siege

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Prologue

Before the stars were counted, there was a rebellion, and it was short. One who had been the brightest of the morning stars stood before the Throne and asked whether the power that cannot be questioned, can still be called just. A few of the loyalists followed him. The Throne did not answer in words. When light settled, the rebels were falling, and they fell for a long time, then the abyss closed around them.

Then there was a garden, Eden, around the Throne. In the middle of the garden there was a tree. Creatures of clay lurked around the garden who looked at its fruit and wanted not the sweetness, but the knowing. For that, they were driven out, banished to dirt. The gates of Eden sealed with fire.

The fire went out a long time ago. No one on this side of the wall noticed when.

Part I.

The eastern gate was the quietest post of heaven, which was why Samael had always liked it. Nothing came to the eastern gate, longer than there had been a way to measure it. Now the dark beyond the battlements was full of lights.

"Count them again", Samael said.

"I stopped counting!", said Raziel. "That was when they were still numbers."

They stood side by side on the rampart, two figures of pale light against a sky that never needed a sun. Below them the gate of Eden stood closed, tall as mountain mentioned in myth. Its golden decoration worn smooth against passing of ages. Beyond it, the light kept arriving, but they were not stars. Stars do not hold formation.

"Word has gone to the Throne?", said Raziel.

"Three times!", said Samael.

"And?..." said Raziel.

Samael was quiet. Far behind them, deep in the heaven, the Seraphim were singing Holy. They were singing since the day star of the morning fell to the abyss. It was a kind of sound you stop hearing, until you listen for the pause.

"Nothing.", said Samael. "We hold the gate. That is the instruction."

"That is the absence of an instruction.", said Raziel.

"In Eden those are the same thing!", said Samael almost laughing.

The lights drew nearer by degree, patient, like a tide of ocean that knows it has all the time there is.

"Do you remember the day we closed Eden?", said Samael.

"I remember the day we closed it behind them!", said Raziel.

Raziel's voice was careful.

"I remember the sword and the fire."

"I remember her face. The Woman. Everyone says she wept."

"She did weep!", said Samael.

"She did not. I was close enough to see. She looked back at the garden. She seemed to be memorizing it. I could see all the Eden details from the reflection on her eyes.", said Raziel.

"She was defiant.", roared Samael.

"She was learning, my dear Sam. It was the only thing she knew how to do by then. It was the only thing He had ever given her, and then, He punished her for it.", said Raziel.

Samael's light flickered.

> "He gave them one law. One. Of all the garden, a single tree, and a single command!", said Samael.
>
> "And He planted the tree in the middle of the garden.", said Raziel.
>
> "A boundary that can not be crossed is not a boundary, it is a Wall! He wanted them to choose.", said Samael angrily.
>
> "Then He can not punish the choosing.", said Raziel softly.
>
> "He did not punish the choosing. He punished the reason.", said Samael.

Raziel turned toward his companion. "They did not eat out of hunger. They ate because they wanted to understand."

> "And what kind of understanding is that?", said Samael. "Show me the knowledge a creature can hold that does not, sooner or later, end here! On top of a wall, counting ships!"

Raziel turned toward the wall of lights, and gazed past the battlements. They stayed quiet for a while.

Part II.

"What did he say?", said Raziel. "When he fell, you were closer than I was."

"He said He would never kneel again!", said Samael.

"This is not what I heard.", Raziel whispered.

"Then what did you hear?", said Samael, annoyed.

"I heard him say: 'Ask Him why'. He was not boasting, Samael. He was asking someone to ask."

"No one asked."

"No. No one did."

The silence between them had weight. Below, in the dark, a single ship detached from the formation and drifted forward. It was larger than the others, the color of old iron dug up from dirt.

"There are stories.", said Raziel. "About what happened down there."

"Rumors.", said Samael, his voice sounded like iron.

"Gabriel who came back from scout said that when the first of them climbed down to him, he laughed. Creatures of mud, he called them. Fallen children of a tyrant's mistake. He would not even look at the man.", said Raziel.

"Then what changed?", Samael asked.

"The man asked him what falling felt like.", Raziel's voice dropped. "Not how to climb out. Not how to take revenge. What it felt like. And the story says that was the question that undid him, because no one in heaven had ever asked him that.", said Raziel.

Samael gazed at the approaching ship for a long moment. "So he pitied them."

"So he recognized them.", said Raziel.

"And the traitor armed them.", said Samael, disgusted.

"He gave them fire. They named the stars in heaven, and learned the way of numbers, and how the light bends around weight. The long road out of the dirt. They did it all by themselves, only with his blessing.", said Raziel.

"A thousand suns", Samael whispered. "They hold a thousand suns, and they were clay."

"They were clay that asked questions.", said Raziel.

Part III.

The iron ship came to rest just beyond the range of the wall's defenses, as if it knew exactly where that range ended. Along its flank, a pale light kindled and held steady.

"They found the gate.", said Samael. "Nothing could find the gate. It was hidden from every eye that was not ours."

"They found it the way they find anything. They kept asking, and nobody ever told them to stop.", said Raziel.

"Someone did once.", said Samael.

"Yeah. I guess He did.", whispered Raziel.

Samael gripped the stone of the rampart, and for the first time in his existence the stone seemed to give a little under his hand. "Do you know what frightens me?", he said. "Not that they will break the gate. They could. I think they could. It's that they might not. That they might stop at the threshold and ask to be let in, and I will not know what to say.", his light flickered.

"We could say what we were told.", said Raziel softly.

"We weren't told anything.", his voice cracked on it. "We were told to hold the gate. That is all we have ever been told. Was it that He trusted us to understand why, or that He never thought we would need to?"

Raziel turned to his old friend to look at his face to search for something.

"Then we are both in trouble."

"We might be the only ones in heaven who have noticed.", said Samael. His face was blank.

"Or we might be the only ones who still can.", said Raziel.

Behind them, the singing faltered. Neither angel turned to see.

Then a voice came across the dark. It was not loud. It was thin, strained by distance and the machinery that carried it. A human voice speaking in a human mouth. And it spoke in the oldest tongue, the one the first two had been taught in the garden, which no one on that side of the wall had heard spoken in ages. It said a single sentence.

Samael's hand moved to reach to the horn at his belt, the long white horn that had not been sounded since the day the rebels fell. "You heard it", he said. "They demand entry."

"They do not demand anything.", said Raziel. "They are asking."

"It was a command.", said Samael in his iron voice.

"It was a question." said Raziel.

"I know what I heard.", Samael roared.

Raziel looked at his friend's face. It was bright with wrath. "So do it.", he said.

The iron ship held its pale light steady. The ranks of armada waited, countless, and still. Behind the walls, the great silence of the Throne pressed outward, neither forbidding nor permitting, and for the first time neither angel could say whether that was patience or absence.

Samael's fist closed around the horn. Raziel rested on the key to the gate. Neither could have said afterward which of them moved first, or whether either had. On the far side of the gate, someone was waiting to be answered.

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